

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Construction and Architecture English

Conversation lab

8 complete workplace dialogues, followed by eight additional role-play cases. Study the exchanges, then make the conversation your own.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For architects, construction managers, project engineers, site supervisors, estimators, owners' representatives, subcontractor coordinators, and design-build teams.

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Inside this conversation lab

Original fictional training conversations in professional English. These are realistic scripts, not transcripts of actual people. The professional roles are the speaker labels; all figures, incidents, and organizations are invented.

01 Design intent

02 Drawing discrepancy

03 Change-order scope

04 Critical-path sequencing

05 Toolbox talk clarification

06 Inspection preparation

07 Punch-list closeout

08 Delay documentation

Then try eight independent role-play cases, followed by feedback criteria and references.

Read it. Hear it. Make it yours.

1. Read the setting. Identify the roles, the immediate problem, and what each speaker needs.
2. Read the whole conversation aloud with a partner. In a group, give a third person the observer role. For three-speaker scripts, assign each professional a separate voice.
3. Notice how the speakers ask a specific question, qualify a claim, disagree, explain a technical point, or agree on a next step. Underline language you would actually use.
4. Cover the script. Recreate the exchange using the situation and professional roles. Keep the meaning, but change the wording.
5. Switch roles and introduce a complication: a missing record, a different priority, an unavailable colleague, or a changed assumption. End with a clear outcome or unresolved question.

Register and terminology

These colleagues use concise professional language. In an internal technical meeting, familiar abbreviations can be natural. With a new colleague or a client, expand unfamiliar terms and check understanding. Keep disagreement directed at the evidence or proposal, and match the degree of certainty to what is known.

Independent study

Speak each role aloud. Pause before the reply and supply your own response before revealing the next line. Record a second version using invented details, then compare its clarity and tone with the script.

Professional context

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

FULL DIALOGUE 01 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Design intent

An architect clarifies a client's request for an open lobby.

Roles: Project architect / Owner's representative

Project architect: When you say open, do you mean fewer visual barriers or a larger circulation area?

Owner's representative: Primarily clearer sightlines from reception to the entrance.

Project architect: Then we can compare layouts without assuming every partition must disappear.

Owner's representative: Show how each option affects circulation, acoustics, cost, and the applicable design requirements.

Project architect: I'll prepare two marked-up plans and identify any consultant reviews needed.

Owner's representative: We'll agree on the preferred direction before you develop the detailed design.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "When you say open, do you mean fewer visual barriers or a larger circulation area?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 02 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Drawing discrepancy

A site team raises a request for information.

Roles: Site engineer / Architect

Site engineer: The structural drawing and reflected ceiling plan show different beam clearances in this corridor.

Architect: Please submit an RFI with the locations, drawing revisions, and the observed conflict.

Site engineer: Installation is scheduled tomorrow. Can the crew choose the dimension that seems more practical?

Architect: Don't resolve a design conflict informally. We'll coordinate the relevant consultants through the review process.

Site engineer: I'll flag the affected work and seek guidance on independent tasks.

Architect: I'll issue the coordinated response through the controlled channel when it's authorized.

Notice the professional language

RFI - Request for information used to resolve an ambiguity, conflict, or missing detail in contract documents or a project scope.

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 03 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Change-order scope

A contractor clarifies whether extra work is authorized.

Roles: Project manager / Owner's representative

Project manager: The revised partition layout adds material and labor. Is the change instruction approved?

Owner's representative: The design change is requested, but the cost and time implications still need review.

Project manager: I'll submit an itemized proposal with assumptions and the effect on the schedule.

Owner's representative: Include credits for omitted work so we can assess the net change.

Project manager: We'll keep the contractual authorization status clear before proceeding.

Owner's representative: I'll route the proposal through the agreed change process and record the decision.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The revised partition layout adds material and labor. Is the change instruction approved?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 04 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Critical-path sequencing

A site team reviews a delayed inspection.

Roles: Construction manager / Planning engineer

Construction manager: The inspection is later than planned. Which activities are actually dependent on it?

Planning engineer: Closing the affected walls depends on acceptance. Other zones may have independent work.

Construction manager: Show the logic links and remaining float rather than moving every task by the same number of days.

Planning engineer: I'll update the schedule using the confirmed inspection window and identify recovery options.

Construction manager: Coordinate those options with the trades and access constraints.

Planning engineer: I'll present the revised forecast with assumptions clearly separated from confirmed dates.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The inspection is later than planned. Which activities are actually dependent on it?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 05 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Toolbox talk clarification

A supervisor checks understanding of a site hazard briefing.

Roles: Site supervisor / Trade foreperson

Site supervisor: Your crew will work beside an active vehicle route. What controls apply to today's task?

Trade foreperson: We need to follow the approved traffic-management plan and confirm the designated work area before starting.

Site supervisor: The route changed yesterday. Has everyone received the current briefing?

Trade foreperson: Not everyone. I'll pause mobilization and arrange the updated briefing.

Site supervisor: Check understanding and raise any conflict with the work plan through the safety process.

Trade foreperson: I'll confirm the agreed arrangements and report any unresolved issue before the crew begins.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Your crew will work beside an active vehicle route. What controls apply to today's task?"
What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 06 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Inspection preparation

A contractor prepares for a statutory inspection.

Roles: Site manager / Inspection coordinator

Site manager: Are we ready for tomorrow's inspection, or are there open prerequisite checks?

Inspection coordinator: Two records are missing, and the relevant specialist hasn't confirmed completion of one item.

Site manager: Let's verify those before declaring readiness.

Inspection coordinator: I'll collect the actual records and confirm the inspector's required scope and access arrangements.

Site manager: If we're not ready, communicate that promptly through the proper channel.

Inspection coordinator: I'll update the inspection request and keep the acceptance status pending until the authorized outcome is recorded.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Are we ready for tomorrow's inspection, or are there open prerequisite checks?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 07 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Punch-list closeout

A team reviews items marked complete.

Roles: Closeout manager / Trade foreperson

Closeout manager: The punch list shows the door adjustments complete. Have they been inspected and accepted?

Trade foreperson: The work is done, but the acceptance check is still pending.

Closeout manager: Separate those statuses. Completion by the trade isn't the same as verified closeout.

Trade foreperson: I'll arrange access for the inspection and attach the work record.

Closeout manager: Include the location references so each item can be checked against the list.

Trade foreperson: I'll update only the items actually accepted and keep any remaining defects visible.

Notice the professional language

punch list - A list of outstanding construction items requiring completion or correction.

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 08 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Delay documentation

A project team discusses a potential delay claim.

Roles: Commercial manager / Site project manager

Commercial manager: We may need to assess the effect of the late information. What contemporaneous records do we have?

Site project manager: RFIs, meeting minutes, daily reports, and the schedule updates from that period.

Commercial manager: Preserve those and distinguish actual delay from assumed impact.

Site project manager: I'll map the affected activities and any mitigation we attempted.

Commercial manager: We'll review the contract's notice and assessment requirements with the appropriate advisers.

Site project manager: I'll provide the factual chronology without presenting entitlement or responsibility as already determined.

Notice the professional language

meeting minutes - A written record of key discussion points, decisions, and agreed actions.

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

Eight more situations to make your own

The following cases are open role plays. They give you facts, contrasting roles, useful expressions, and a short model response. Use what you learned from the complete dialogues to create a longer exchange.

Preparation: two minutes. Conversation: three to five minutes. Feedback: one minute. Switch roles and repeat with the second-round challenge.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 01

Design Intent and Client Requirements

SHARED CASE

A client describes a meeting space as "flexible" but has not specified occupancy, furniture changes, or audiovisual needs.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

What activities should the space support, and how often will the layout change? Let's clarify occupancy and equipment needs so the design brief gives the team a usable direction.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 02

Drawings, Specifications, and RFIs

SHARED CASE

A drawing and specification appear to describe different finishes for the same area. The site team needs a documented clarification.

Role A | Responding professional

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Useful expressions

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know ...

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could the design team confirm the intended finish and relevant revision? I'll identify the conflicting references in a request for information rather than assume which instruction takes precedence.

Second round

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 03

Change Orders and Cost Control

SHARED CASE

A client requests an additional partition after pricing is agreed. Cost and schedule effects have not been assessed.

Role A | Responding professional

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You want the preferred outcome but can accept one tradeoff. Ask for two options, then state which condition you can accept and which still needs approval.

Useful expressions

We can ..., provided that

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm

Cover this until after your first attempt

We can review the partition as a proposed change. Let's assess its cost and schedule effect through the agreed change process before confirming that it is included in the current price.

Second round

The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 04

Schedule, Sequencing, and Critical Path

SHARED CASE

A delivery delay affects a task on the current critical path. A lookahead schedule still shows the original sequence.

Role A | Responding professional

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Useful expressions

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Cover this until after your first attempt

The delayed delivery affects a critical-path task. I'll update the lookahead and show the feasible resequencing options for review instead of leaving the original dates unexplained.

Second round

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 05

Site Safety and Toolbox Talks

SHARED CASE

In a toolbox-talk exercise, an instruction says to use "the right protection" without identifying the task or approved requirement.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Which task and approved safety requirement does this refer to? Please have the authorized person clarify the instruction before work proceeds. The language needs to be specific enough to understand and check.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 06

Permitting, Inspections, and Code Issues

SHARED CASE

An inspection note identifies outstanding items, but a progress email says the area is fully approved.

Role A | Responding professional

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Useful expressions

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could you confirm the inspection status and the items still outstanding? I'll correct the progress wording so it does not imply approval that has not been documented.

Second round

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 07

Quality, Punch List, and Closeout

SHARED CASE

A closeout list contains eight items, with three completed and five awaiting review. The incoming coordinator needs the supporting records.

Role A | Responding professional

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are taking over the work. Ask what remains open and repeat back the critical status or responsibility. Point out one detail that would be unsafe or misleading to assume.

Useful expressions

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is

The record shows

Please confirm who has accepted

Cover this until after your first attempt

Three items are complete, and five await review. The list links each item to its record and responsible party. Please confirm the remaining review steps before reporting closeout as finished.

Second round

The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 08

Claims, Disputes, and Documentation

SHARED CASE

A project team wants to say a delay automatically entitles it to compensation. The contract and records have not been reviewed.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

The delay and its effects should be documented, but entitlement requires appropriate contract and legal review. I'll separate the factual record from any conclusion about a claim.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.